

Now let us just suppose, for the sake of the argument, that Peter sent five copies of his letter, one to each province. What would the implications be for the transmission of its Text? It means that you multiply the process and progress of transmission by five! It means that you have the beginnings of a ‘majority text’ very early on. It means that the basic integrity of the text would be guaranteed (the more so if God was superintending the process). If Peter sent out more than five copies, so much the more. And what about James; how many copies would it take to reach “the twelve tribes that are in the dispersion” (verse 1)? (Does not the very term ‘dispersion’ suggest that they were widely scattered? And what if the ‘twelve tribes’ is literal?) Peter’s second letter does not list the five provinces, but 3:1 would appear to indicate that he was targeting the same area.

To see that I did not pull the idea of multiple copies out of thin air, let us consider 2 Peter 1:12-15. Verses 12 & 13 refer to repeated reminders while he is still in his ‘tent’, which would be his own ongoing activity; so why the ‘moreover’ in verse 15? In the NKJV verse 15 reads: “Moreover, I will be careful to ensure that you always have a reminder of these things after my decease”. Well, how can you ‘ensure’ that someone will ‘always have a reminder’ of something? It seems clear to me that the something has to be written down; a reminder has to be in writing, to be guaranteed. So what is Peter’s intention? He specifies “a reminder of these things”, so what are the ‘these things’? They are evidently the things he will discuss in this letter. But he must be referring to something more than the initial draft of the letter (or the verse becomes meaningless)—hence, multiple copies.¹

¹ It was Dr. Mike Loehrer, a pastor in California, who called 2 Peter 1:12-15 to my attention and got me started thinking about it. With reference to verse 15 he wrote me the following: “Could choosing to use *mneme* with *poieo* in the middle voice mean to ensure a way of always being able to validate a memory? In those days most people could not afford their own copy of a writing, and the church would no doubt become the repository of an autograph anyway. The usual way of getting the Scripture back then was by committing it to memory when hearing it during the public reading. Having multiple autographs in multiple locations would definitely ensure a way of validating a memory. Even if the leaders of a church or synagogue were imprisoned and their autograph was seized or destroyed, they could rest assured that they could locate another autograph to validate their memory of the way a verse or passage was actually written.”

The idea of validating a memory is as interesting as it is suggestive. Peter’s use of *μνημη*, basically reflexive, with *ποιεω* in the middle voice, makes Mike’s suggestion a reasonable one, as it seems to me. It goes along with the multiple copies. Irenaeus puzzled over verse 15 and came up with the suggestion that Peter intended to get copies of Mark’s Gospel to those regions. Evidently the idea of multiple copies was not strange to him. And how about other books?